



Uppsala Cathedral

The Nordic countries' largest and tallest cathedral and the seat of the primate of Sweden

Uppsala Cathedral was begun in around 1270, after an earlier cathedral located a few miles away was damaged by fire. Adverse weather, outbreaks of plague, and shortage of funds conspired to slow construction, and the building was still incomplete when it was finally consecrated in 1435. The towers at its western end were added in 1470–1489, redesigned in the 17th century, and seriously damaged by fire in 1702.

Later addition

In 1885, the Swedish architect Helgo Zettervall, a proponent of the Neo-Gothic style, made major—and often criticized—changes to the cathedral; he added the tall spires that make the cathedral as high (at 390 ft/118.7 m) as it is long. For centuries, until it lost the role to Stockholm's Storkyrkan in 1719, Uppsala held the coronations of the kings of Sweden. Following the Reformation, several of Sweden's kings and queens were buried here, along with several bishops and notable scientists, including the pioneering botanist Carl Linnaeus.

△ NEO-GOTHIC RENOVATION

The Coronation Vault, 89 ft (27 m) high, was decorated in the 1880s in Neo-Gothic style. The renovations also uncovered some original medieval frescoes.



▷ BRICK-BUILT CATHEDRAL

Uppsala was built largely in brick in the Baltic Gothic style seen across northwest and central Europe, where stone for construction was scarce.

BALTIC GOTHIC

The cathedral was designed by French master builders, including Étienne de Bonneuil, and its Latin-cross floor plan is typical of other Gothic cathedrals from the 12th century. However, due to lack of locally available stone, the cathedral was constructed in red brickwork; only its chancel pillars and some details were built from the more usual limestone blocks. This distinctive style is known as Baltic or Brick Gothic.

